

Review Article

The Cambridge History of the Mongol Empire and the State of the Field: A Review Article

Márton VÉR*

Centre for the Study of Manuscript Cultures (CSMC), University of Hamburg, Hamburg, Germany

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ABSTRACT

This review article examines *The Cambridge History of the Mongol Empire* (CHME), a landmark two-volume work that synthesises recent scholarship on Mongol Eurasia.¹ It situates CHME within the historiographical trajectory of Mongol studies, assessing its structure, key arguments and contributions to the field. The article compares CHME with earlier major volumes, including *The Cambridge History of Inner Asia: The Chinggisid Age* and *The Mongol World*, highlighting differences in editorial approach, thematic focus and historiographical impact. It also discusses some of the potential future directions in the study of Mongol Eurasia.

KEYWORDS

Mongol Empire, historiography, world history, Global Middle Ages, Chinggisid exchange, research trends

The study of Mongol Eurasia is clearly having a moment. This is evidenced by the fact that the two volumes and nearly 1,500 pages of *The Cambridge History of the Mongol Empire* (henceforth CHME) was published just 14 years after *The Cambridge History of Inner Asia: The Chinggisid Age*, edited by Nicola di Cosmo, Allen J. Frank, and Peter B. Golden (2009). The latter volume was the first attempt within the Cambridge History series to synthesise what is known about Mongol

* Email: marton.ver@uni-hamburg.de

¹ An earlier version of this review article was discussed in a Zoom meeting with several colleagues on 10 February 2025, whose feedback and comments were of great assistance to the author. The author also benefited significantly from discussions with Nicholas Matheou, whose forthcoming piece on recent trends in the study of the Mongol Empire will appear in the *English Historical Review*. The author recommends reading the two essays together, as they complement each other in many ways. Naturally, any errors in this article remain the sole responsibility of the author.

Eurasia and its aftermath. Moreover, another comprehensive volume, *The Mongol World*, edited by Timothy May and Michael Hope, was published in 2022 as part of The Routledge Worlds series, offering an extensive discussion of Mongol Eurasia across more than 1,000 pages. If one were to ask why Mongol Eurasia has recently attracted such scholarly attention, the most concise response would be the opening sentence of the CHME introduction: “*The Mongol Empire changed the world*” (p. 1). This statement encapsulates the significant strides made in Mongol studies over the past decades and reflects the growing recognition of the Mongols’ transformative role in world history. Before turning our attention to the details of how the results of recent decades’ research are summarized in the CHME, it is worth considering its background first.

The dedication of the two volumes of CHME to the late Thomas T. Allsen (1940–2019), David O. Morgan (1945–2019), and György Kara (1935–2022) is symbolic in several respects. Although these three scholars represented different approaches within Mongol studies, each played a pivotal role in transforming the field over the past decades, a process that ultimately culminated in the publication of this work.

György Kara was an expert in the entire spectrum of Altaic philology, with a special focus on the languages, culture and history of the Mongols. He edited and translated many important Mongolian sources, wrote a seminal book on the history of Mongolian writing systems and book culture (in Russian: 1972, in English: 2005), and trained several generations of scholars at the Eötvös Loránd University in Budapest and Indiana University in the United States, equipping them with the skills to read Mongolian and Turkic sources in original.

David O. Morgan was a specialist in Iranian studies, his research focusing on the Middle East during the Mongol period (13th–14th cc.). As the first scholar to bring the Mongol Empire to a wider audience through his classic textbook *The Mongols*, first published in 1986 and reprinted numerous times, he laid the groundwork for broadening the field’s accessibility. Beyond this influential book, he inspired many students as a distinguished teacher at SOAS in London and the University of Wisconsin-Madison.

Finally, Thomas T. Allsen was a historian whose research focused on Mongol Eurasia. His work was pioneering in many ways, but perhaps its most influential aspect was his mastery of Chinese, Persian and Russian, which enabled him to simultaneously analyse textual sources from these key historiographical traditions and thus to study the history of Mongol Eurasia in its entirety. By integrating these sources with his understanding of the nomadic cultural complex of the Mongols, he introduced a comprehensive approach to the field, breaking down long-standing disciplinary boundaries shaped by the dominance of area studies in higher education systems. The paradigm shift he initiated was characterised by two key developments: the emergence of a new cultural history and the so-called holistic perspective, i.e. the study of the Mongol Empire not only from a regional perspective but also in its broader Eurasian context (Morgan 2015).

These advancements in Mongol studies, including the training of new generations, the unprecedented outreach of the field beyond what was once a narrow circle of specialists, and the transformation of scholarly approaches to Mongol Eurasia, have collectively contributed to the foundation for this Cambridge History, with each of the three scholars playing a pivotal role in these developments in their own distinctive ways. Moreover, all three contributed outstanding chapters to CHME, yet sadly, none of them lived to see its publication.

The author of this review had the privilege of participating as a Ph.D. student in the inaugural event of the project that led to these two volumes. This event, an international conference followed by a summer school in Jerusalem in 2014, brought together many of the contributors

to CHME. Several of them were close colleagues, students, or otherwise connected to the three eminent scholars to whom the volumes are dedicated. In this sense, CHME can be seen as the product of two academic generations. The first, which among others included the three dedicatees, initiated a fundamental transformation in the study of the Mongol Empire from the 1980s onwards. The second, which has played a crucial role in consolidating this shift over the past two decades, includes the two editors of CHME, Michal Biran and Hodong Kim. Through the work of these two generations, the Mongol Empire has been firmly positioned within the historical canon, standing alongside other empires traditionally regarded as central to world history. At the same time, the outlines of a third, more recent generation—many of whom were Ph.D. students in 2014—can also be discerned in these volumes. While only a few appear as authors, like Marie Favereau or Na'ama Ohanna-Arom, this third generation's first major works are already cited, marking their growing presence in the field.

Both the field of Mongol studies in general and this volume in particular are fundamentally shaped by two defining characteristics of the Mongol Empire. First, it was the largest contiguous land empire in world history, covering approximately two-thirds of the Afro-Eurasian “Old World” and exerting a profound influence on territories beyond its borders. Second, partly as a result of these vast spatial dimensions, the essential written sources on Mongol Eurasia have survived not in one or two languages, as is the case with most empires, but in more than a dozen. Furthermore, reflecting broader trends in modern historiography, the inclusion of additional categories of sources—particularly archaeological and visual evidence, as well as the findings of scientific research—has become increasingly significant in historical inquiry.

Given this complexity, it is fair to say that no single researcher can claim comprehensive expertise on all aspects of the Mongol Empire or every element of the volume under discussion. However, the publication of a Cambridge History always marks a significant milestone in any field of study, and this is especially true for an emerging field such as research on Mongol Eurasia. With this in mind, this review article focuses on three key issues: (1) the structure and main arguments of the work as a whole, (2) its significance for both the study of the Mongol Empire and world history, and (3) future directions for research suggested by the volume, along with the tasks that lie ahead for the next generation of scholars. Naturally, in addressing the latter two aspects, some issues that fall more closely within the author's expertise will be discussed in greater detail than others.

The first volume, *History*, is divided into four parts. The first part (pp. 19–396) consists of five chapters on political history, presenting the state of the art. It begins with a chapter on the United Empire (1206–1260) (R. W. Dunnell), followed by four chapters dedicated to the successor states: Yuan China (C. P. Atwood), the Ilkhanate (S. Kamola and D. Morgan), the Jochid Ulus, commonly known as the Golden Horde (M. Favereau and R. Yu. Pochekaev), and Mongol Central Asia, covering the Chaghadaid and Ögödeid territories (M. Biran). While highlighting their shared Chinggisid heritage, ideology, and institutional frameworks, these chapters also outline the distinctive developments of each successor state. The second part (pp. 397–654) comprises nine chapters and presents two types of thematic histories. The first three chapters introduce institutions and concepts that emerged during the period of the United Empire but continued to serve as cohesive factors after 1260, during the era of the ‘Mongol commonwealth’: overarching imperial institutions (H. Kim), including the imperial structure (*ulus*), the mobile courts (*ordo*), the army, civil administration, chancellery practices, and the postal system (*jam*); key aspects of Mongol imperial ideology (T. T. Allsen), and the structure and operation of the Mongol military

machine (T. May). The remaining six chapters in part two explore cross-cutting themes across Mongol Eurasia: economic (A. Kuroda), religious (J. Elverskog), artistic (R. Prazniak) and scientific exchange (M. Rossabi and R. G. Morrison), environmental history (N. Di Cosmo), the roles of women and gender under Mongol rule (B. Birge and A. F. Broadbridge). The third part (pp. 655–776) presents regional histories beyond the imperial centres, where the Mongols often exercised power through local rulers or dynasties. These chapters examine the impact of Mongol rule on the peripheries and their connections to the empire's core, beginning with Mongolia itself (M. Rossabi), which was the centre of the empire in its early years but gradually became a periphery again, particularly after 1260. The lands of Koryŏ (D.M. Robinson), Georgia and the Caucasus (L. Pubblici), Siberia (T. T. Allsen), and the Rus' principalities (L. N. Langer) are also discussed here. The final part, *External Histories* (pp. 777–851), examines the Mongol Empire's influence on regions beyond its borders, which, despite mostly remaining outside direct Mongol rule, were profoundly shaped by their interactions with the empire such as (Western) Europe (N. Di Cosmo), the Arab Middle East (R. Amitai), and South Asia (T. Sen).

The second volume, *Sources*, sets CHME apart even within the prestigious Cambridge History series. While the first volume maintains a high scholarly standard by presenting the state of the art, the second volume adds a unique dimension by providing extensive and detailed overviews of the primary sources available for studying the empire. It is divided into two main parts: *Literary Sources* (pp. 1–396) and *Archaeological and Visual Sources* (pp. 397–522). The first part, 'Literary Sources', consists of sixteen chapters, each dedicated to a distinct linguistic or historiographical tradition. The volume begins with chapters on the source groups typically considered foundational for the study of the Mongol Empire: Persian (C. Melville), Chinese (B. Birge and X. Liu), Mongolian (Gy. Kara), Arabic (R. Amitai and M. Biran), Rus'ian (D. Ostrowski), and Western European (primarily Latin) sources (P. Jackson). Beyond these well-edited chapters on major literary traditions, the volume also includes lesser-used source groups, such as Armenian (B. Dashdondog), Georgian (R. Metreveli), Middle Turkic and Chaghatay (D. Deweese), Tibetan (K. Kollmar-Paulenz), Korean (K.-H. Lee), Syriac (P. G. Borbone), Uyghur (D. Matsui), Greek (I. Vásáry), Tangut (R. W. Dunnell), and Hebrew (N. Ohanna-Arom) sources. The second part, 'Archaeological and Visual Sources', shifts the focus from written texts to material culture. Separate chapters examine archaeological sources from Mongolia and the Yuan dynasty (N. Shiraishi), the Ilkhanate (T. Masuya), the Jochid Ulus (M. G. Kramarovsky), and the Chaghadaid Khanate (A. V. Pachkalov). The final chapter explores visual sources (Sh. Blair and Sh. McCausland), including Mongol-era art, manuscript illustrations, textiles, and architectural influences across Eurasia.

The chapters in the first volume can be grouped into three broader categories. The majority present the state of the art, incorporating developments from the past one and a half decades. Some chapters address broader themes that are rarely examined as a whole, such as economic, religious, scientific, and artistic exchange or imperial ideology. Lastly, a number of chapters explore topics that have been largely overlooked in the literature, including the history of Mongolia after 1260 and the Mongols' relationship with Siberia. The comprehensive survey of source groups in the second volume of CHME highlights the complexity of the field and underscores why this volume will be an indispensable reference. It is not only valuable for undergraduate and graduate students or scholars from other disciplines, but also for specialists focused on specific regions or topics of Mongol Eurasia, as it provides essential guidance for navigating sources related to other parts or aspects of the empire.

Due to its nature, every edited volume faces certain challenges, and CHME is no exception. Nine years passed between the project's kick-off event and its publication, which, given the complexity of coordinating forty-three contributors, is not an unusually long timeframe. Ensuring consistency across all chapters is always a challenge, but in such circumstances, it becomes even more difficult, making it nearly impossible to achieve the same level of up-to-date scholarship in every section—particularly in a rapidly evolving field like the study of Mongol Eurasia. Naturally, the chapters of the two volumes were submitted at different times, and by examining their bibliographies, one can reasonably estimate when each was completed. For instance, most chapters in the first part of the first volume (*Political History*) appear to have been last updated in 2019–20, whereas the majority of chapters in the second part (*Thematic Histories*) seem to have been finalised around the mid-2010s, with only a few later self-references. Such discrepancies are an inevitable by-product of a large-scale project of this kind, yet readers should remain aware of them.

A concrete example is Hodong Kim's thought-provoking chapter on imperial institutions, which appears to have been finalised around 2015, with a self-reference added in or after 2019. Towards the end of its section on chancellery practices, the author writes (p. 432): “the *writing style called taitou* (“elevating the head”) in China was widely adopted in the decrees of the Mongol period. Where one encounters words referring to Heaven, the emperor, or other revered objects, the line of the text stops and a new line starts, elevated between one and three characters above the height of the regular line. There are also other variations of taitou such as leaving an empty space in front of a revered word, not changing lines, or putting a blank for such a word and writing that word at the head of the line... Although this taitou format did not originate in the steppe tradition, it was adopted by the Mongols and became a standard chancellery practice during the Mongol period in all the uluses.” From this formulation, with mentioning the Chinese name of the concept (*taidou*) and the explicit rejection of a possible steppe inheritance, one would conclude that this characteristic peculiarity of the Mongol decrees must have been a direct borrowing from the Chinese tradition that was adopted to Mongol script. Nevertheless, Adam Benkato's edition of Sogdian letters (2018: 53–59) convincingly outlines a Central Asian (or Silk Road) tradition of indentation for addressees in letters that can be followed up from the Mugh documents from Sogdiana (8th century) through the Sogdian letters from Khotan and Turfan (8th to 11th cc.) up to the Uyghur letters (9th to 14th cc.). If we keep in mind that the Mongols borrowed their script from the Uyghurs and adopted it to their own language, a Central Asian inheritance does not seem improbable at all. Moreover, the earliest Preclassical Mongolian monuments such as the Stele of Yisüngge (1224/5) or the legend on the seal of Güyük (1246) show definite and strong Uyghur influence (Rachewiltz & Rybatzki 2010: 159–170). Furthermore, the former bears the earliest example of elevation of a ruler's name (Chinggis Khan) in a Mongolian text, while the latter was sealed on the letter from Güyük to Pope the Innocent IV, the earliest example of indentation in a preserved document produced by a Mongol chancellery. A further peculiarity of this letter is that it was written in Persian, but the preamble which is followed by four indented lines is in Turkic, with both sections written in Arabic script. Bearing all this in mind, the assumption that the practice of elevation came to the Mongolian chancellery from the Central Asian tradition seems quite convincing. Our understanding of imperial Mongol administration has changed considerably since the mid-2010s, primarily thanks to the edition and analysis of Uyghur and Mongolian sources from eastern Central Asia, but unfortunately these developments could not be integrated into the chapter.²

² For overviews of these developments, see Vér 2019: 22–44 and Matsui 2023: 3–59.

Other chapters did not have to face the challenge of such a rapidly changing field. This is the case of Allsen's seminal essay on the Mongols and Siberia (pp. 734–752). It is understandable that there is much less historiography on the history of the Mongols in Siberia than in other parts of the empire, since the amount of relevant written sources is probably the smallest here. Nevertheless, as Allsen points out, an understanding of the dynamics of the relationship between the forest zone and the steppe is essential to an understanding not only of Mongol history, but also of the history of Eurasian pastoral nomads in general, and thus of Eurasian history itself. Accordingly, the chapter outlines why the northern Eurasian forest zone was a crucial source of raw materials and prestige goods essential to the nomadic political economy and a strategic place of retreat in times of need. Allsen explains why the “forest-steppe” (Russian *lesostep*) to the south of the taiga was an all-important zone of contact between the nomads and the forest people. The author situates the discussion of the Mongol period within a broader historical framework, tracing developments from the first nomadic empire, the Xiongnu Confederation (ca. 200 BCE–200 CE), to the 17th century, when Russian and Qing colonisation of the region severed nomadic polities from Siberia. This disconnection ultimately led to the decline of nomadic military power in Eurasia. This chapter is a fine example of how the combination of historical, archaeological, linguistic and anthropological data can help to counterbalance a relative lack of written sources, deepening understanding of the world historical significance of an often-neglected territory.

Unlike Allsen's chapter on Siberia, Nicola Di Cosmo's contribution on the climatic and environmental factors that shaped Mongol conquest presents a summary of findings from a rapidly developing and relatively new field of research, which has significantly refined our understanding of various aspects of Mongol expansion. Following a general introduction, the author structures the chapter into four sections, each focusing on a broader region: Mongolia; northern China and Manchuria; arid Central Asia—further subdivided into the Altai, the Tien Shan and the Tarim Basin, and the Aral Sea region; and finally, Russia and Eastern Europe. Due to the data available, the discussion is limited to the period between 1209 and 1242, i.e. from the conquest of the Tangut state to the Mongol withdrawal from Hungary. However, while almost every summary of a subchapter begins with a disclaimer that the available information is either difficult to interpret or that more data would be needed for more conclusive results, the review of scientific research over the last two decades or so enables the author to outline a coherent and clear narrative. According to this, climatic changes, albeit with many different regional variations, ultimately led to favourable overall environmental conditions from around 1200, which played an important role in Mongol military activity and may have contributed to, or at least not hindered, the success of their expansion. One notable exception is the final major military event of the period under discussion: the Mongol withdrawal from Central Europe in 1242, to which a combination of a harsh winter and heavy precipitation may have contributed. An event of world historical significance, the Mongol withdrawal ultimately marked the westernmost endpoint of the Mongol campaigns. The incorporation of climatic and environmental data into our understanding of Mongol expansion is one of the most important new directions in research, although this picture will certainly change in the future as new methods provide more and more reliable data, making this chapter a very important addition to the CHME, especially when compared to earlier handbooks.

If the reader is left with a slight sense of incompleteness, this may be due to the fact that the chapter does not engage with some of the critical responses to the ‘environmental hypothesis’ concerning the Mongol withdrawal of 1242, which continue to shape scholarly debate in this

area. The seemingly abrupt retreat has long been of interest to scholars, and the ‘environmental hypothesis’ (Büntgen & Di Cosmo 2016), which posits adverse short-term environmental and climatic conditions as the main cause of the retreat, has led to a productive scholarly discourse.³ This remarkable chapter would benefit from even a brief summary of the debate, since it touches on one of the most important methodological challenges of our time: how we interpret and integrate scientific data into historical narratives. It is hardly a coincidence that another of today’s most vibrant scholarly discussions centres on a topic that similarly requires the integration of historical and scientific evidence: the relationship between the history of the plague and the Mongol conquest of Baghdad.⁴ Beyond the answers such debates seek to provide to important historical questions, the way we conduct interdisciplinary discussions will have a fundamental impact on the future of the field, especially in a scholarly environment where interdisciplinary understanding and collaboration are becoming ever more essential. A major reference work like the CHME naturally aims to shape the thinking of future generations. Perhaps the most effective way to demonstrate how an interdisciplinary field operates is by showing how scholarly disagreements are engaged with and worked through.

As noted above, the entire second volume of the CHME, dealing with sources, is an extraordinarily important contribution to the development of the discipline, and can serve as an example should someone in the future undertake to edit a volume of Cambridge History for other, similarly highly interdisciplinary fields of research, such as Silk Road studies. From this volume, the reviewer would like to highlight only those chapters most closely related to his area of expertise. György Kara’s chapter on Mongolian sources is a true masterpiece, reflecting his deep familiarity with the material down to individual manuscripts. Similarly, Devin DeWeese’s chapter on Middle Turkic and Chaghatay Turkic sources, along with Dai Matsui’s overview of the Uyghur sources, provide thorough and well-informed surveys of the available material. Both chapters not only outline the most important developments in the history of scholarship up to the present but also introduce the relevant editions of the sources.⁵

The key arguments of CHME are synthesised in the *Epilogue*, co-authored by the editors and placed at the end of the first volume. Biran and Kim argue that the Mongols’ nomadic culture – defined by its mobility, adaptability, and redistribution – was the primary driving force behind the extensive geopolitical, cultural, religious, and economic transformations they brought about across Eurasia. Mongol rule, they contend, facilitated unprecedented cross-cultural exchanges, laying the foundations for the transition from the medieval to the early modern world and even influencing the Age of Exploration. While acknowledging the immense devastation wrought by the Mongol conquests, the authors offer a more nuanced perspective by emphasising their pragmatic and controlled use of terror. They highlight that destruction was often a strategic measure rather than indiscriminate brutality and note that some of the most economically productive regions remained largely unscathed.

³ In a recent study, Di Cosmo (2024) reflects on the ongoing debate, enumerating the most important contributions: Pinke *et al.* 2017, Büntgen & Di Cosmo 2017, Laszlovszky *et al.* 2018, Pow 2019, Laszlovszky *et al.* 2023.

⁴ Fancy & Green 2021, Brack *et al.* 2024 and Green & Fancy 2024.

⁵ Two further items can be added to the relatively limited number of Uyghur sources found west of the Uyghur homeland. One is a short Uyghur inscription in the Mausoleum of Mār Benham, some thirty kilometres southeast of Mosul in northern Iraq (Harrak & Ruji 2004). The other is a golden ring found at the Veliko Turnovo monastery in Bulgaria with the Uyghur inscription *kutlug bolsun* (Vladimirov 2013).

To describe the profound cultural, economic, and religious transformations of this period, the authors introduce the term ‘Chinggisid exchange’. The frequency with which a discipline generates new terminology can often be an indication of the rate at which the field is evolving. In the case of Mongol studies, the past decades have seen the creation, adoption, and occasional rejection of numerous terms, such as ‘Pax Mongolica’, ‘Mongol Commonwealth’, ‘Mongol Moment’ and ‘Tsunami Strategy’. The introduction, adaptation, and critique of these terms reflect scholars’ ongoing efforts to refine their understanding and articulate new insights. In this instance, Timothy May (2012: 22–23 and *passim*) introduced the term ‘Chinggis exchange’ to describe the impact of Mongol conquests on world history, while Marie Favereau’s (2021: 6–7 and *passim*) ‘Mongol exchange’ emphasised the significance of the post-1260 period. Biran and Kim (854, n. 5) subsequently merged these concepts into ‘Chinggisid exchange’ to encompass the entire ‘Mongol moment’, a term that is likely to remain influential in the field for years to come.

To describe the Chinggisid exchange, the authors (p. 854) argue that Mongol rule brought together three major civilisations—Sinitic, Islamic, and Orthodox Christian—alongside the nomadic cultures of the Eurasian steppes. While it is undoubtedly challenging to encompass all the key components that played major roles in the Mongol Empire, some crucial elements seem to be missing from this framework. Neither of the authors of the *Epilogue* can be accused of overlooking Central Asia—on the contrary, both Biran and Kim have significantly contributed to advancing our understanding of this often-understudied yet highly important region of the empire. However, the above formulation excludes the role of the initially non-Muslim eastern fringes of Central Asia, particularly the Uyghurs and Tibetans. The administrative expertise of the Uyghurs was instrumental during the formative period of the Mongol Empire, while the Tibetan Buddhist tradition spread widely across East Asia under Mongol rule.⁶

Later, they (p. 858) write: “*The main axes of Mongol cross-cultural exchange ran between the Sinitic and Islamic civilizations, whereas the Orthodox Christians were a relatively marginal partner in this exchange.*” While it is undeniable that the Sinitic and Islamic civilizations played major roles in Chinggisid exchange, the lands, cultures, and—most importantly—the peoples situated between these two civilizations actively contributed to Eurasian exchange during the Mongol period. To name just a few crucial innovations that spread on a Eurasian scale under Mongol rule: whether it was trade partnerships (*ortog*), thematic multilingual vocabularies, or the postal system (*jam*), all of these had roots in Central Asia as well. In their early (pre-Chinggisid) evolution in Central Asia, people of various religious affiliations—Manichaeans, Buddhist, Christian, Muslim, and others—as well as speakers of diverse languages, including Chinese, Turkic, Tocharian, Sogdian, and Tibetan and others, played key roles in shaping these institutions. Although the popular usage of Silk Road is problematic, it may still be the most fitting way to describe the broader context from which these innovations emerged as Silk Road cultural complex or civilisation. This concept still awaits a detailed, monograph-length study, but from our perspective, some of its most distinctive characteristics are clear: it was a multilingual, multicultural, and multi-religious environment where sedentary and nomadic populations interacted continuously for centuries. The skills and attitudes cultivated within this cultural complex—regardless of linguistic or religious affiliation—were fundamental to the Chinggisid exchange especially in its early and formative period. It is not a coincidence finally, that we see such high numbers of Central Asians

⁶ The growing prominence of Tibetan Buddhism under Mongol rule is acknowledged elsewhere in the *epilogue* when religious changes are discussed in particular (p. 862).

regardless of their religious affiliation in Mongol service in every corner of the Mongol Empire in its first decades and that they still played a key role later. The following example showcases this point.

A Chinese booklet, preserved on two fragments (Ch 3716 and Ch/U 8152) from the Berlin Turfan Collection, contains excerpts from the Chinese primer *Qianziwen* 千字文 (Thousand Character Essay) along with a colophon. The booklet was created by repurposing a manuscript of a Chinese Buddhist text and was found in Yarkhoto, a village near Turfan, the heartland of the Uyghur territories in the Mongol period and today part of the Xinjiang Uyghur Autonomous Region in the PRC. The colophon is written in Chinese characters but follows Old Uyghur (Turkic) syntax and has recently been reconstructed with the assumption that it was read in Old Uyghur (Yakup 2023). Some of the Chinese characters are in forms used during the reign of Empress Wu Zetian (r. 690–705 CE), a notable deviation from standard usage. Additionally, the text includes a Sogdian-Uyghur enumeration of the numbers one to five, where the Sogdian numerals are written incorrectly. The colophon states that the text was recorded in Jiaohe 交河, which is the Chinese name of Yarkhoto, the same location where it was found in the early 20th century. The date given—the 34th year of the *Tianxi* 天禧 era—corresponds to 1211 CE in the Western Liao calendar, just two years after the Uyghur ruler voluntarily submitted to Chinggis Khan. The author, identified as Šingtsün Tutong, was a Uyghur who also donated a surviving manuscript of an Old Uyghur Buddhist text. On the final page, the title appears in Old Uyghur written in the Uyghur script: *[ming uʒ]ik-lär-ning čizigi* positioned to the right of the Chinese title. What does this booklet reveal about its author? Šingtsün Tutong was a wealthy Uyghur who did not reside in the centres of either Sinitic or Islamic civilisation, nor even in the capital of the Uyghur realm, but in the nearby settlement of Yarkhoto. Nevertheless, he copied excerpts from one of the most popular Chinese primers, adding a colophon in Chinese characters—some of which had long fallen out of standard use and had been employed half a millennium earlier. Additionally, he inserted a few numbers, albeit incorrectly, in Sogdian, an Iranian language that had died out about two centuries earlier. Moreover, he used Chinese characters in a way that suggests they were intended to be read in Old Uyghur. Šingtsün Tutong was literate in both his mother tongue and Chinese, demonstrating enough proficiency in the latter to employ unique characters, presumably as a display of knowledge. He was also aware of the existence of the Sogdian language centuries earlier and likely understood its connection to his own Old Uyghur literary tradition. Given that he could presumably communicate in his native tongue with Turkic-speaking Muslims from western Central Asia, many of whom spoke Persian and Arabic, it becomes clear why such literati of the Silk Road cultural complex played an important role in the early history of the Mongol Empire. In other words, the cultural resources of the Islamic and Sinitic civilisations were immense, but the Central Asian (or Silk Road) yeast was much needed to make it a Chinggisid bread.

One of Allsen's most influential contributions was his demonstration that the Mongols were not merely passive facilitators of exchange but actively mobilised and redistributed people, goods, knowledge, and institutions, integrating vast regions into a shared imperial space. Their policies fostered extensive trade and communication, linking both the overland and maritime Silk Roads and creating an unprecedented level of economic interconnectedness across Eurasia (2001). Following in Allsen's footsteps, the editors place particular emphasis on the role of mobility within the Chinggisid exchange, arguing that it permeated nearly every aspect of Mongol life and governance. This mobility manifested in various forms, including military campaigns, forced deportations, voluntary and organised migrations, the movement of itinerant courts, and

the trade in enslaved people. The editors point out too that Mongol religious policies fundamentally transformed the religious landscape of Eurasia. While initially remaining committed to their native steppe-based beliefs, the Mongols patronised and engaged with multiple faiths. This policy ultimately contributed to the expansion of Islam and the spread of Tibetan Buddhism.

Finally, they outline the lasting influence of the Mongol imperial model on successor states across Eurasia, from East through Central and South Asia to West Asia and Eastern Europe. Mongol administrative, military, and economic structures shaped the development of early modern empires such as Ming China, the Timurid Empire and its successor states, the Ottoman Empire, the Principality of Moscow, and later the Russian Empire. Yet, paradoxically, Mongol expansion also contributed to the decline of nomadic political power. The very networks they fostered—facilitating trade, governance, and institutional development—ultimately played a role in the marginalisation of nomadic polities, as increasingly centralised states and gunpowder empires came to dominate Eurasia. The *Epilogue* concludes by asserting that the Mongols fundamentally reshaped Eurasia. As Janet Abu-Lughod first pointed out (1989), although their empire eventually disintegrated, its institutional, economic, and cultural legacies endured, laying the foundation for the growing interconnectedness that characterises the modern world.

While this review focuses on CHME, it is worth comparing its structure and emphasis to two other major recent publications mentioned at the outset: *The Cambridge History of Inner Asia: The Chinggisid Age* (2009, hereafter CHIA) and *The Mongol World* (2022, hereafter TMW). CHIA was conceived as a continuation of *The Cambridge History of Early Inner Asia* (1990), edited by Denis Sinor, which covered the region's history from its earliest periods up to the rise of the Mongols. CHIA aimed to provide a historical overview of Inner Asia from the 13th century to the colonisation of Eastern and Western Central Asia by the Qing dynasty and the Russian Empire between the 17th and 19th centuries. In this respect, the legacies of the Mongol period were a central theme in that volume. The second part of the book, which examines the legacies of the Mongol conquests, is particularly noteworthy. The topics discussed—institutional development, taxation, trade, migrations, and cultural transmissions—reflect the rise of cultural history in the study of the Mongol Empire and have become some of the most widely researched areas in recent years.

TMW devotes its most substantial section to the Mongol conquests, offering a detailed examination of how various regions of Eurasia were integrated into the Great Mongol State (*Yeke Mongghol Ulus*) across thirteen chapters. At the same time, its overall structure, like that of CHME, reflects the unfolding and impact of the 'cultural turn' in Mongol studies. Both CHME and TMW dedicate multiple sections to the diverse forms of Eurasian exchange facilitated and shaped by Mongol rule, encompassing religious, administrative, material, intellectual, and artistic dimensions. Furthermore, both recent publications dedicate several chapters to how the Mongols were perceived by their subjects and neighbours. However, there are significant differences between CHME and TMW in terms of editorial approach. The editors of CHME opted for broader thematic chapters, whereas TMW divides similar topics across multiple chapters. For instance, CHME addresses imperial institutions in a single chapter, while TMW dedicates an entire section (*Administration and Political Structure*) with six chapters to the same subject. While TMW's approach allows for more detailed discussions of individual institutions, CHME's structure highlights the interconnectedness of these various aspects of Chinggisid governance. A similar contrast can be seen in the treatment of religion. CHIA included only one chapter on Islamisation, whereas TMW expands this theme significantly with seven chapters covering

different religious traditions. In contrast, CHME presents various religions in a single chapter, offering a more unified perspective on the role of religious exchange under Mongol rule. A further distinction between CHME and TMW is that, while the former aims to present the state of the art in the field, many chapters in the latter introduce new research findings.

Taken together, the three publications are a clear indication of fundamental changes, both in the perception of the discipline and in the direction of research. Most importantly, the Mongol Empire itself became interesting enough for the broader scholarly audience for major publishers to undertake the publication of specialised volumes. A significant change in the two recent publications is the number and composition of the contributing authors. CHIA had sixteen authors, several of them writing two or more chapters. In contrast, more than forty experts contributed both to TMW and to CHME. As the editors (p. 9) noted in the CHME introduction, ‘in quite a few cases we paired two scholars for one chapter, in order to fully cover the discussed subject’. Several contributors of the two recent volumes are from beyond Europe and North America. This shift is particularly welcome given the enduring perception that global history remains predominantly shaped by ‘Western’ scholars.

It is also clear that by the early 2020s the dominant trends of recent decades, both in terms of the ‘cultural turn’ and the ‘holistic perspective’, have come to full fruition. It is also reassuring to see that the volumes of CHME strike a careful balance between the two extreme perceptions of the Mongols that have shaped earlier scholarship. The editors successfully navigate between the portrayal of the Mongols as disorganised, bloodthirsty oppressors responsible for the suffering of much of Eurasia (the so-called ‘Tatar yoke’) and the overly idealised vision of Mongol rule as an era of peace and prosperity in all aspects, from economy to culture (‘Pax Mongolica’). This balanced approach ensures that the Mongol period is presented with the nuance it deserves, securing its rightful place in world history.

A careful reading of CHME reveals not only the past and present state of research, but also at least three emerging trends that may shape developments in the near future. One of the most pressing developments is the growing need for closer collaboration, driven by two key factors. First, the increasing specialisation of scholars, necessitated by the expanding depth of knowledge even within niche sub-fields, requires a more focused approach. Second, the rising complexity of interdisciplinary topics calls for joint efforts among specialists. This necessity extends beyond collaboration within the humanities to fostering stronger partnerships with natural scientists and IT experts. Many chapters in these volumes are co-authored by scholars with complementary expertise, demonstrating the advantages of such an approach. Given the vast geographic scope of the Mongol Empire and the multilingual nature of its surviving sources, future research in Mongol studies will increasingly rely on similar levels of cooperation. This urgency becomes even more apparent when considering that most key institutions of the Mongol Empire—such as the chancellery, the *keshig* (imperial guard), the privileged merchants (*ortoq*) and others—still lack comprehensive monographic studies that cover the entire empire. This is particularly important as these institutions were the very structures that created and maintained the unity of the empire across the different cultural areas spanning most of Eurasia. Nevertheless, since sources have survived from every corner of the empire, in numerous different languages, a comprehensive understanding of these institutions requires their comparative analysis. An individual researcher must either rely on translations or engage in collaborative work. As many of these sources have yet to be translated into modern languages, cooperation will inevitably play an increasingly significant role in future research. It does not seem like a risky bet to say that the traditional image

of the solitary, omniscient humanities scholar is gradually giving way to a more collaborative scholarly paradigm.

Another foreseeable trend is the growing importance of new textual sources, particularly documentary materials that, for now, are available only as original manuscripts in archives. Over the past decades, a key development in Mongol studies has been the comparative analysis of different historiographical traditions across Eurasia, with Chinese and Persian sources forming the two most extensive corpora. This approach has been instrumental in identifying and mitigating the biases inherent in these sources while also mapping their carefully constructed narratives. However, these texts remain elite productions, shaped by authors situated within the power centres of the empire(s). The second volume of CHME makes it clear just how many documentary sources have become accessible in different languages in recent decades. Comparative analysis of these documents has the potential to open new research avenues, shedding light on regions far from imperial centres and offering insights into the lives of non-elites and the inner workings of the Mongol administrative system. While philological research on these documents has already made significant contributions to the field, the growing availability of primary materials and the increasing number of specialists are likely to expand the scope of inquiry even further. Thus, it would not be surprising if, as in European medieval studies, research shifts towards archival sources once the major chronicles have been thoroughly examined. Furthermore, alongside documents, archives also preserve manuscripts of narrative sources, creating opportunities for material philology, an approach that has gained prominence in medieval studies over the past three decades. This approach, which takes into account not only the texts themselves but also the physical characteristics of written artefacts, is also likely to become increasingly important in the study of Mongol Eurasia. The potential of such perspectives is well illustrated by the Nomads' Manuscripts Landscape project in Vienna (<https://www.oeaw.ac.at/iran/nomansland/>), which highlights the insights gained from returning to original manuscripts.

Closely connected to this is the third trend that seems likely to unfold in the near future: the challenge of reconciling global and local perspectives within historical research. While the Mongol Empire played a crucial role in integrating Eurasia, its impact varied significantly across different regions. CHME aims to find a balance between macro-historical narratives and detailed regional analyses, ensuring that both the broader imperial framework and localised experiences within it are adequately addressed. Future research will definitely need to follow this path further. In other words, over the past decades, scholars of the Mongol Empire have successfully moved beyond regional perspectives to adopt global approaches; in the coming years, research will likely focus on connecting the global with the local. Beyond an 'archival turn' and interdisciplinary collaborations between specialists in the humanities and sciences, digital humanities will play an increasingly important role in this endeavour. The impact of sophisticated prosopographical databases, such as that developed within Michal Biran's ERC project *Mobility, Empire and Cross-Cultural Contacts in Mongol Eurasia*, is already evident in CHME and in project members' publications. Hopefully, such tools will become accessible to the broader scholarly community in the future, facilitating the reconstruction of the worlds of lower-ranking elites and non-elite groups within the Mongol Empire.

Despite the few minor remarks made in this review, the two volumes of the CHME undoubtedly represent a milestone in the study of Mongol Eurasia. By bringing together the work of several generations of scholars from a wide range of disciplines, Biran and Kim have showcased the remarkable development of the field and laid a solid foundation for future research on Mongol

Eurasia. Hopefully, they mark the transition from a Mongol moment in research to the institutionalisation of the Mongol moment—a period when early-career scholars specialising in Mongol Eurasia will have career prospects comparable to those of colleagues focusing on modern periods. Given the realities of the academic job market, particularly in Europe and the US, such an outcome may seem utopian at present. Yet, the CHME itself stands as clear evidence of how far a field of research can advance within just a few decades. The question now is whether the institutional framework can keep pace.

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